

The Rosen Fibration

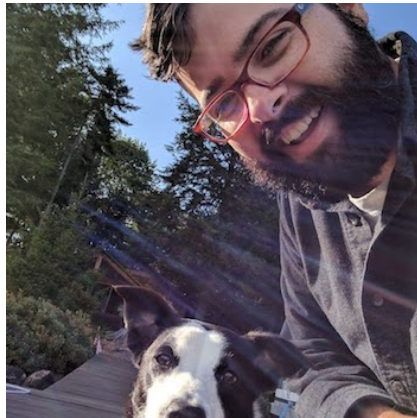
ACT26 — Tallinn

Fosco Loregian Amahury J.L. Díaz Sean Maley

Tallinn University of Technology / SUNY Binghamton

How it started

At the end of October 2025, Amahury (L) and Sean (R, with doggo) contacted me.



- Applying category theory to biology: 'vindicating' Robert Rosen, who believed category theory was a foundation for life sciences.

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- His work foreshadows ideas in endofunctor algebra theory, monads, systems and processes—concepts we understand **only now**.
- This project (with Amahury and Sean) is a work in progress; comments welcome.

Robert Rosen (1934–1998)

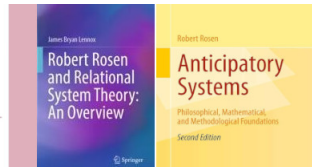


- Attended lectures of Eilenberg, then Mac Lane
- Wrote extensively on category theory in biology
- not always correct...

Wrote **before** Yoneda lemma, adjunctions, monads ... and stayed outside the category theory community.

ESSAYS
ON
LIFE
ITSELF

ROBERT ROSEN



MR systems

A 'living system' is capable of

M) etabolism

MR systems

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R) eparation

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M) etabolism (f)

R) eparation (Φ)

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A **candle** has f but not Φ ; **Ni-Ti alloy** has Φ (seals microcracks) but no metabolism.

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core idea: there is an intrinsic self-referentiality property for alive systems (“closure under efficient causation”: $\exists \bar{a}. \lambda x. \Phi(f\bar{a})x = \lambda x. fx$) but lacks monoidal closed categories (1958).

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Our goal: study the diagram $A \rightarrow B \rightarrow [A, B]$ in a suitable sense. Can we build a category

$$\sum_{A, B: \mathcal{C}} \{A \xrightarrow{f} B \xrightarrow{\Phi} [A, B]\}?$$

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$$\sum_{A, B: C} \{A \xrightarrow{f} B \xrightarrow{\Phi} [A, B]\}?$$

Yes — **MRS** is the **Rosen fibration** of the title.

Incoherent systems

Working Assumption

$\mathcal{C}$ is symmetric monoidal closed, with all needed (co)limits.

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Definition

An **incoherent MR system** is $A \xrightarrow{f} B \xrightarrow{\Phi} [A, B]$ in $\mathcal{C}$. A morphism $(\ell, r) : (f, \Phi) \rightarrow (g, \Psi)$ makes

$$\begin{array}{ccccc} A & \xrightarrow{f} & B & \xrightarrow{\Phi} & [A, B] \\ \downarrow l & & \downarrow r & & \searrow [A, r] \\ A' & \xrightarrow{g} & B' & \xrightarrow{\Psi} & [A', B'] \\ & & & & \nearrow [\ell, B'] \\ & & & & [A, B'] \end{array}$$

commute. The total category **iMRS** has triples $(A, B; f, \Phi)$ as objects and morphisms as above.

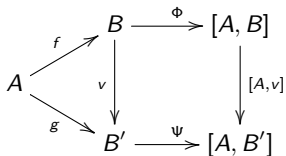
I use agda, btw

```
1 record iMR2 (A B : Obj) : Set (o ∪ ℓ) where
2   constructor ⟨_,_⟩
3   field
4     f : A ⇒ B
5     φ : B ⇒ [ A , B ]o
6
7 record iMR2o : Set (o ∪ ℓ) where
8   field
9     A B : Obj
10    ξ : iMR2 A B
11
12 record iMR2⇒ (X Y : iMR2o) : Set (o ∪ ℓ ∪ e) where
13   module X = iMR2o X
14   module Y = iMR2o Y
15   module ξX = iMR2 X.ξ
16   module ξY = iMR2 Y.ξ
17   field
18     l : X.A ⇒ Y.A
19     r : X.B ⇒ Y.B
20     eqf : r ∘ ξX.f ≈ ξY.f ∘ l
21     eqφ : [ l , id ]1 ∘ ξY.φ ∘ r ≈ [ id , r ]1 ∘ ξX.φ
```

Reasoning fiberwise

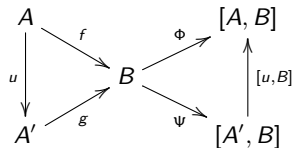
() Fix A : category $\mathbf{iMRS}^A$ ($\ell = \text{id}$)

- same A , varying B ,
- morphisms $v : B \rightarrow B'$ with



() Fix B : category $\mathbf{iMRS}_B$ ($r = \text{id}$)

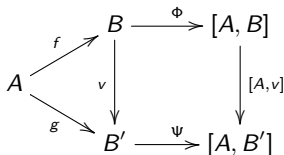
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Reasoning fiberwise

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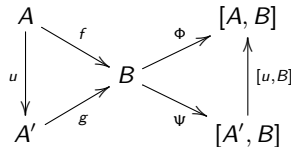
```

1 record iMR2A (A : Obj) : Set (o u ℓ u e) where
2   field
3     B : Obj
4     ξ : iMR2 A B
5
6 record iMR2A (A : Obj) (X Y : iMR2A A) : Set (o u ℓ u e) where
7   module X = iMR2A X
8   module Y = iMR2A Y
9   module EX = iMR2 X.ξ
10  module EY = iMR2 Y.ξ
11  field
12    v : X.B → Y.B
13    eqf : v ∘ X.f = EY.f ∘ u
14    eqφ : [ id , v ] ∘ EX.φ = EY.φ ∘ v

```

(☞) Fix B : category $\mathbf{iMRS}_B$ ($r = \text{id}$)

- same B , varying A ,
- morphisms $u : A \rightarrow A'$ with



```

1 record iMR2B (B : Obj) : Set (o u ℓ u e) where
2   field
3     A : Obj
4     ξ : iMR2 A B
5
6 record iMR2B (B : Obj) (X Y : iMR2B B) : Set (o u ℓ u e) where
7   module X = iMR2B X
8   module Y = iMR2B Y
9   module EX = iMR2 X.ξ
10  module EY = iMR2 Y.ξ
11  field
12    u : X.A → Y.A
13    eqf : EX.f ∘ u = EY.f ∘ u
14    eqφ : EX.φ ∘ [ u , id ] = EY.φ

```

Incoherent systems

Equivalent characterization of an incoherent MR system:

- Fix A ; one can think of the category of iMRS 'based at A ' as the category of algebras for the endofunctor of $\mathcal{C}$

$$X \mapsto A \otimes (I + X)$$

- Fix B ; the category of iMRS 'based at B ' is the slice $\mathcal{C}/[I + B, B]$.

A slightly more refined characterization, that works only in a distributive Cartesian base, is the following:

- An iMR based at A is a parametric, pointed dynamical system of type $\xi \approx (1 \xrightarrow{f} B; B \xrightarrow{\phi} B)$ with certain coKleisli maps;
- More simply, an iMR seems to be a **lens** $(\begin{smallmatrix} A \\ B \end{smallmatrix}) \rightarrow (\begin{smallmatrix} B \\ B \end{smallmatrix})$. (There is more to this story I haven't looked into...)

There is a problem!

() $A \mapsto \mathbf{iMRS}^A$ is functorial (reindexing $v^* : \mathbf{iMRS}^{A'} \rightarrow \mathbf{iMRS}^A$).

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$(\text{reindex}) A \mapsto \mathbf{iMRS}^A$ is functorial (reindexing $v^* : \mathbf{iMRS}^{A'} \rightarrow \mathbf{iMRS}^A$).

$(\text{reindex}) B \mapsto \mathbf{iMRS}_B$ is **not** functorial; the categories $\mathbf{iMRS}_B$ are displayed, not fibered, over $\mathcal{C}$.

```
1 left : {u : A → A'} → Functor (IMR2A A') (IMR2A A)
2 left {A} {A'} u = record
3   { Fu = λ { x →
4     let module x = IMR2A x
5     in record
6       { B = x.B
7       ; ξ = λ IMR2.f x.ξ → u , [ u , id ]1 • IMR2.φ x.ξ }
8     }
9   ; Fv = λ { {x} {y} f →
10     let module x = IMR2A x
11     module ξx = IMR2 x.ξ
12     module y = IMR2A y
13     module ξy = IMR2 y.ξ
14     module f = IMR2A f
15     in record
16       { v = f.v
17       ; eqf = begin f.v • f.ξx.f • u = ( sym-assoc )
18         ( f.v • f.ξx.f ) • u = ( f.eqf ) • (refl )
19         f.ξy.f • u
20       ; eqφ = begin [ id , f.v ]1 • [ u , id ]1 • f.ξx.φ = ( sym-assoc • ([ [-,-] ]-commute ) • (refl) • assoc )
21         [ u , id ]1 • [ id , f.v ]1 • f.ξx.φ = ( (refl) • ( f.eqφ ) • sym-assoc )
22         ([ u , id ]1 • f.ξy.φ ) • f.v
23       }
24   ; identity = λ {A} → refl
25   ; homomorphism = λ {X} {Y} {Z} {f} {g} → refl
26   ; F-resp = λ x → x
27 }
28
```

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A **coherent MR system** based at $A, B \in \mathcal{C}_0$ consists of

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- $f : A \rightarrow B$ in $\mathcal{C}$;
 - a **natural transformation** [cf. ^a and ^b] $\Phi : \text{cod} \Rightarrow [A, \text{cod}]$, where $\text{cod} : \mathcal{C}^{[0 \rightarrow 1]} \rightarrow \mathcal{C}$ is the codomain functor.
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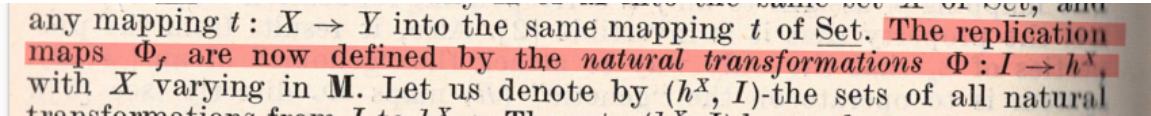
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any mapping $t : X \rightarrow Y$ into the same mapping t of Set. The replication maps Φ_f are now defined by the *natural transformations* $\Phi : I \rightarrow h^X$, with X varying in $\mathbf{M}$. Let us denote by (h^X, I) -the sets of all natural transformations from I to h^X .

Coherent MR systems

Φ is pointed by f ; naturality means

commutes whenever $\begin{array}{ccc} X & \xrightarrow{h} & Y \\ \ell \downarrow & & \downarrow r \\ X' & \xrightarrow{k} & Y' \end{array}$ is an arrow $h \rightarrow k$ in the category $\mathcal{C}^{[0 \rightarrow 1]}$.

$$\begin{array}{ccc} Y & \xrightarrow{\Phi_h} & [A, Y] \\ r \downarrow & & \downarrow [A, r] \\ Y' & \xrightarrow{\Phi_k} & [A, Y'] \end{array}$$

Towards the Rosen fibration

The profunctor of MR systems | 

MRS(A, B) is a profunctor $\mathcal{C}^{op} \times \mathcal{C} \rightarrow \mathbf{Set}$; its action on morphisms $u : A' \rightarrow A$, $v : B \rightarrow B'$ is

$$\begin{aligned} \mathbf{MRS}(A, B) &\longrightarrow \mathbf{MRS}(A', B') \\ (A \rightarrow B, \Phi) &\longmapsto (A' \rightarrow A \rightarrow B \rightarrow B', [u, \text{cod}] \circ \Phi) \end{aligned}$$

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```
1 MRS-Profunctor : Bifunctor (Category.op C) C (Setoids (o u l u e) (o u l u e))
2 MRS-Profunctor = record
3   { F0 = λ { (A , B) → MR2-Setoid A B }
4   ; F1 = λ { {(A , B)} {(A' , B')} } (u , v) → record
5     { _{$}_ = λ {⟦ f , φ ⟧ → ⟦ v ∘ f ∘ u , (nHom u ∘r Cod) ∘v φ ⟧ }
6     ; cong = λ { ⟦ f , φ ⟧ } { ⟦ g , φ' ⟧ } (f≈g , φ≈φ') →
7       (∘-resp≈ Equiv.refl (∘-resp≈ f≈g Equiv.refl))
8       , (λ {x} → ∘-resp≈r (φ≈φ' {x}))
9     }
10 }
```

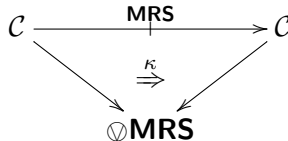
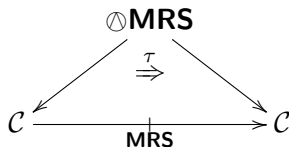
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To the profunctor **MRS** one can associate several categories:

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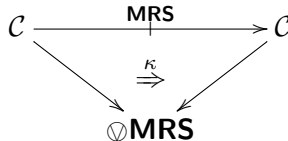
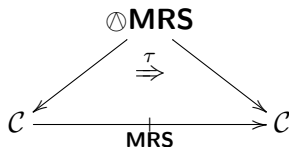
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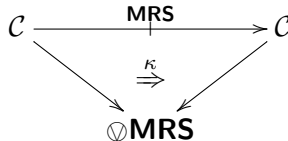
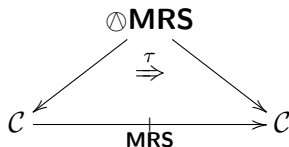


- The category of **elements** $\mathcal{E}(\mathbf{MRS})$ via pullback;

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- The category of **elements** $\mathcal{E}(\mathbf{MRS})$ via pullback;

The two-sided discrete fibration $\mathcal{C} \leftarrow \bigoplus \mathbf{MRS} \rightarrow \mathcal{C}$ is the Rosen fibration of the title.

Rosen fibration(s)

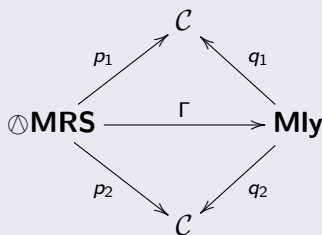
Arbib¹ showed each MR system determines a **Mealy automaton** (input A , output B , state $[A, B]$), functorially:

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There is a total category of Mealy automata and a fibred functor



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Rosen fibration(s)

Fibration of repair maps

The presheaf $Rep : \mathcal{C}^{op} \rightarrow \mathbf{Set}$, $A \mapsto \mathbf{Cat}(\mathcal{C}^{[0 \rightarrow 1]}, \mathcal{C})(cod, [A, cod])$ has the **fibration of repairs** $\mathcal{E}(Rep)$ as its category of elements.

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Objects: $(A, \Phi : cod \Rightarrow [A, cod])$; **morphisms** $u : (A, \Phi) \rightarrow (A', \Upsilon)$ making $\Phi = \Upsilon * [u, cod]$.

$$\begin{array}{ccc} & cod & \\ \Upsilon \swarrow & & \searrow \Phi \\ [A', cod] & \xrightarrow{[u, cod]} & [A, cod] \end{array}$$

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The fibration of repairs is a **discrete, coreflective subfibration** of the tabulator:

$$\mathcal{E}(Rep) \begin{array}{c} \xleftarrow{k} \\ \xrightarrow{\mathbb{T}} \\ \xleftarrow{\mathbb{J}} \end{array} \mathcal{T}(\mathbf{MRS}) \quad k(A, B; \xi @ (f, \Phi)) = (A, \Phi)$$

Rosen and others^{2 3 4}

²M. W. Warner, "Representations of (M,R) -systems by categories of automata". Bull. Math. Biology 44, 661–668 (1982).

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Rosen and others^{2 3 4} considered longer MR systems

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$$A \longrightarrow B \longrightarrow [A, B] \longrightarrow [B, [A, B]] \longrightarrow \dots$$

defined by a **Fibonacci rule** $M_0 = A$,

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$$\begin{array}{ccccc} A & \longrightarrow & B & \xrightarrow{R(f,\Phi)} & [A, B] \\ & & \parallel & & \parallel \\ & & X & \xrightarrow{M(g,\Psi)} & Y \longrightarrow [X, Y] \end{array}$$

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$$\begin{array}{ccc} \mathbf{MRS}_3 & \longrightarrow & \mathcal{T}(\mathbf{MRS}) \\ \downarrow & \lrcorner & \downarrow M \\ \mathcal{E}(\mathbf{MRS}) & \xrightarrow{R} & \mathcal{C}^{[0 \rightarrow 1]} \end{array}$$

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 \parallel & & \parallel \\
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 \end{array}
 \qquad
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This 'vindicates Rosen': it makes *precise*, in *modern terms*, an idea he had decades ago.

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Thanks!